

HABBINSON

PERSONALITY & ENTREPRENEURSHIP SCHOOL

— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

How to give choices the right way

Want to get kids to cooperate without yelling? Give two choices instead of one order. Learn how offering choices ends power struggles and builds decision-making skills.

5

ACTION STEPS

6

EXPERT FAQs

3

RESEARCH SOURCES

THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

"Put your shoes on." Silence. "Put your shoes on NOW." A standoff. Sound like your mornings? Most parents try to win these battles with more force. There's a smarter way, and it takes the fight out of the room in seconds.

— THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

How to give choices the right way

QUICK ANSWER

Why do choices work better than commands? A command triggers a child's need to push back and protect their sense of control. A choice satisfies that same need — the child still gets to decide something — while steering them toward the outcome you want. You win on the goal; they win on the autonomy.

— WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

2025 work from BrainFacts on modeling emotional regulation shows that calm, respectful interactions lower conflict far better than force.

Sources: CDC | Neuroscience Society | APA

DO THIS

5 everyday swaps from order to choice

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

1**"Get dressed." → "Do you want to**

dress yourself or have me help?"

2**"Stop watching TV." → "One more song**

or one more page, then we're done — you pick."

3**"Eat your dinner." → "Do you want**

the big spoon or the small fork?"

4**"Go to bed." → "Teeth first or pajamas first?"****5****"Clean up." → "Do you want to**

pack the blocks or the books first?"

— KEEP AN EYE OUT

How to give choices the right way

- ✓ Two options, both fine with you: "Bath now or after this show ends?"
- ✓ Keep the non-negotiable fixed: the bath happens; only the when is theirs.
- ✓ Make it concrete, not open-ended: "Carrots or cucumber?" beats "What veggie do you want?"
- ✓ Two is plenty. Too many choices overwhelm a young child and stall the moment.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

Quick answers for parents

Isn't giving choices just letting my child win?

No. You decide the two options, and both lead where you want to go. The child controls only the small detail. You keep authority over the goal while giving them the sense of control they need to cooperate.

How many choices should I offer?

Two is the sweet spot for young children. More than that overwhelms them and stalls the moment. As kids get older, you can widen it, but two clear options work for most everyday standoffs.

What if my child refuses both choices?

Stay calm and pick for them: "Looks like blue shoes today." Keep your tone light, not punishing. The goal is to keep momentum without turning it back into a battle of wills.

Does this work for teenagers?

Yes, just scale it up. Instead of shoe colors, offer choices about how and when they meet a responsibility: "Do you want to do homework before or after dinner?" Teens crave autonomy even more than little kids.

Won't my child see through the trick?

It isn't a trick — it's respect. You're genuinely sharing control over small things. Kids feel the difference between being manipulated and being trusted with a real decision.

Can I use choices to stop tantrums?

Choices work best before a meltdown, not during one. Once a child is flooded, calm them first. Offering options to a screaming child usually backfires; wait for the thinking brain to come back online.

READING HELPS. PRACTICE STICKS.

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